

“We Have Achieved A Milestone By Having Government School Children Participate In Championships Alongside Their Private School Counterparts”



Can corporate CSR funds truly make a difference? Rooted in the belief that technical skills should be accessible to all, Estonia-based non-profit Robotex International, established 24 years ago, has empowered over a million children across seven states in India. EFY's Yashasvini Razdan interviewed South Asia Head Robotex International and Director Robotex India, Payal Manan Rajpal, to uncover the secret behind their success.

PAYAL MANAN RAJPAL
BOARD MEMBER AND SOUTH ASIA HEAD,
ROBOTEX INTERNATIONAL, WITH STUDENTS

Could you explain the different programmes you have got?

We have outlined three distinct programmes:

- **Robotics for rural schools.**

This initiative targets imparting future skills, particularly in robotics, to schools in rural areas within the country.

- **STEM robotics labs.** This programme involves establishing STEM, Robotics, and AI labs in government schools. These labs provide students with access to cutting-edge technology and the equipment necessary to upskill for the modern world.

- **Girls who build robots.** The ‘Girls Who Build Robots’ programme promotes STEM education for girls, aiming to reduce dropout

rates and empower them for STEM careers.

What is the duration of these programmes?

We propose a three- to five-year programme duration, incorporating teacher training initiatives, and ultimately transitioning towards sustainability. The extended engagement period ensures that after the initial years, the educational institutions can effectively continue and manage the programme independently. Typically, our commitment to the same donor spans five years, fostering a long-term and impactful collaboration.

How is this course integrated into the regular academic curriculum for school children?

The curriculum we have developed draws inspiration from Finland and is crafted by our team in Estonia. Despite Estonia's small population of 1.5 million, the country boasts the highest number of unicorns per capita globally. We have tailored the curriculum to include AI, robotics, and other technical skills, aligning with formal education trends in India.

Our curriculum spans levels one to five, with two primary goals. First, students should create a capstone project in areas such as AI, coding, IoT, robotics, and cybersecurity. Second, the robots built should be eligible for participation in championships. We have achieved a milestone by having government school children participate in championships alongside their private school counterparts.